

Public Comment Speech – Police Building Proposal

Good evening, Chair Muller and Members of the Board.

My name is Monica Strauser, and I am a Kennett Township resident. I want to start by saying clearly: I support our police department, and I support addressing the very real deficiencies in the current facility.

But I continue to oppose the **current proposed plan**.

At its core, my concern is simple: this appears to be a building designed for a **future police force**, not the department we have today.

And that distinction matters—because you are not asking residents to pay for a hypothetical future. You are asking us to commit real tax dollars now, without clearly defining what that future is.

Right now, there is no publicly available **policing strategic plan**.

No 5-year plan.

No 10-year plan.

No clearly defined staffing projections.

No stated service model.

Yet the building being proposed assumes all of those things.

That is backwards.

Planning should start with a **policing plan**, then move to **population and growth projections**, and only then to a facility sized to support that plan.

Instead, we are being asked to approve the facility first—and figure out the rest later.

That is not responsible planning. And given past financial mismanagement, it is not acceptable to residents.

This is not just a \$10 million decision.

This building brings **long-term financial obligations** that have not been fully presented to the public:

- What are the **annual maintenance costs**?
- What are the projected increases in **staffing, salaries, and pensions**?
- What additional **equipment and operational costs** will this facility require?
- What does this look like not just in year one—but in years 5, 10, and 20?

Those numbers matter just as much as the construction cost—and they have not been clearly shared.

At the same time, the current plan still has not demonstrated that it is the **smallest adequate solution**.

Your own materials show this design has been reduced multiple times and is still being “right-sized.” That tells us something important: the plan is not yet proven to be minimal.

Residents are still waiting for answers to basic questions:

- What is the **smallest “must-have” version** of this building?
- What would it look like if it were sized only for **current staffing and operations**?
- Which spaces are **required**, and which are **future capacity or preference**?
- What functions can be **shared, phased, or kept in the existing township building**?

A legitimate function does not automatically require a dedicated room.

And current operating reality should matter.

We have a department that operates 18 hours a day, with overnight coverage handled elsewhere. Public data show a workload that is heavily non-criminal. That supports fixing key deficiencies—like evidence handling, public access, and safety—but it does not automatically justify a large, highly specialized facility without clearer justification.

If future growth is part of the argument, then show it.

What are the **population projections**?

What is the **build-out scenario based on current zoning**?

What is the expected **tax base growth**?

And if that growth is real, then why aren’t we taking a **phased approach**, so future residents help pay for future expansion?

Instead, current residents are being asked to pay upfront for a future that has not been defined.

That is not fair, and it is not necessary.

So tonight, my request is straightforward:

We need **radical transparency**.

We need you to:

- Commit to releasing detailed financial projections—including long-term operating costs
- Publish a **policing strategic plan**
- Provide **population and tax growth projections**
- Show a **true minimum-sized option** and a **phased alternative**

And if those plans do not yet exist—then we are asking you to create them before moving forward.

Because it is beyond comprehension that we would greenlight a project of this scale for a department that does not have a publicly defined strategic plan.

I am not asking what would be ideal.

I am asking what is **necessary now**—and what can responsibly wait.

Until that level of planning and transparency is provided, I urge the Board not to move forward with the current proposal.

Thank you.